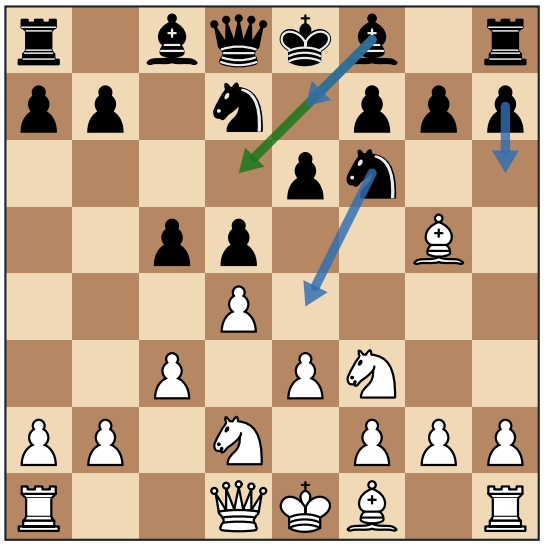
Queen's Pawn Game

ECO A40-D05 | 82 named lines | Queen's Gambit / Slav family

In one sentence: The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Memory pattern: c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.



Main line: 1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5 e6 4.e3 c5 5.c3 Nbd7 6.Nbd2

Key ideas

1. Challenge d5 with c4: if Black takes (QGA), White regains the pawn and gets center.
2. QGD: Black holds d5 with ...e6; the light bishop is the problem piece.
3. Slav: ...c6 keeps the light bishop free for ...Bf5.
4. Exchange Carlsbad: White plays the minority attack b4-b5; Black counters with ...Ne4 and ...f5.
5. Black's freeing moves are ...c5 and ...e5; White's are e4 and Qc2/Bd3 kingside play.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.12** (equal, depth 16). Best: Bd6.

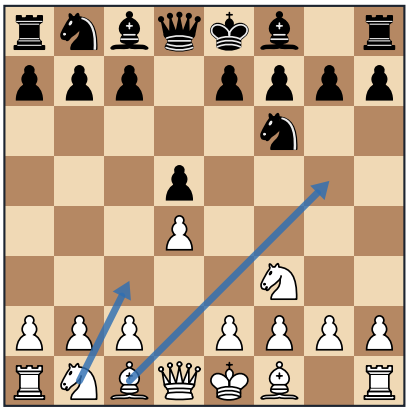
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.
2. Where does my king go?	Both sides castle kingside; the king is rarely attacked early.
3. Best minor pieces?	White: Bg5/Bf4, Nc3/Nf3, Bd3, Rc1. Black: Nbd7, Bb7 or Bf5, Be7, Rc8.
4. Main middlegame plan?	White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

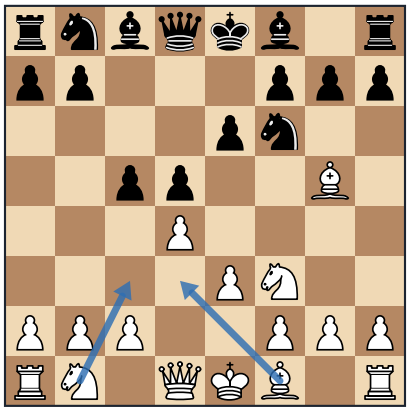
The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5 e6 4.e3 c5 5.c3 Nbd7 6.Nbd2

Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d5	Hold the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
3. Bg5	Pin Nf6. Develops the bishop to g5.
3... e6	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. e3	Support d4. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... c5	Free the position. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
5. c3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
5... Nbd7	Develops the knight to d7.
6. Nbd2	Develops the knight to d2.



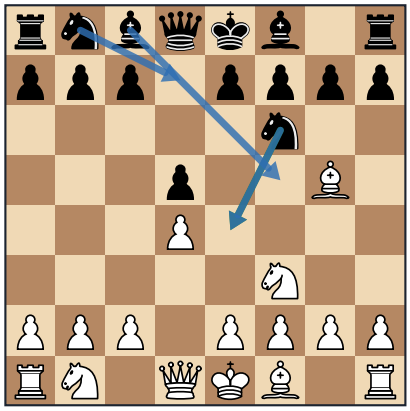
After 1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6



After 3 Nf6 3.Bg5 e6 4.e3 c5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

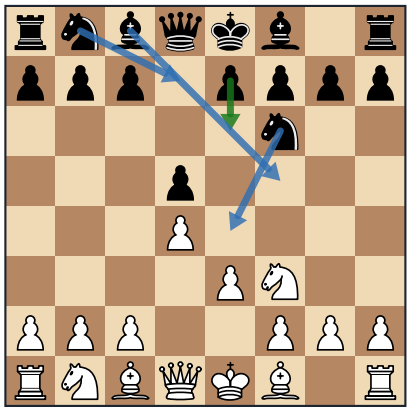


Position after the line

Torre Attack D03 | 16 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5`

Stockfish: **-0.21** (equal, depth 15). Best next move: Ne4.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Grünfeld Variation, Breyer Variation, Gossip Variation

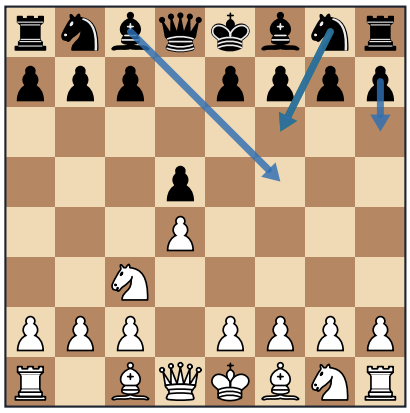


Position after the line

Colle System D04 | 11 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3`

Stockfish: **+0.10** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: e6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Anti-Colle, Grünfeld Formation, Traditional Colle

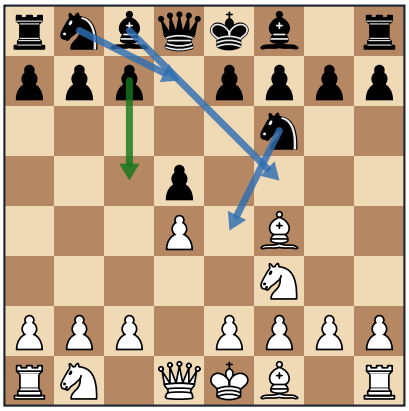


Position after the line

Chigorin Variation D00 | 10 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Nc3`

Stockfish: **-0.03** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Alburt Defense, Anti-Veresov, Fianchetto Defense, Irish Gambit

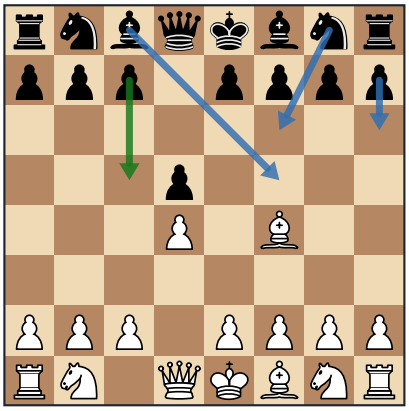


Position after the line

London System D02 | 7 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bf4`

Stockfish: **+0.08** (equal, depth 16). Best next move: c5.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: with e6, Pterodactyl Variation

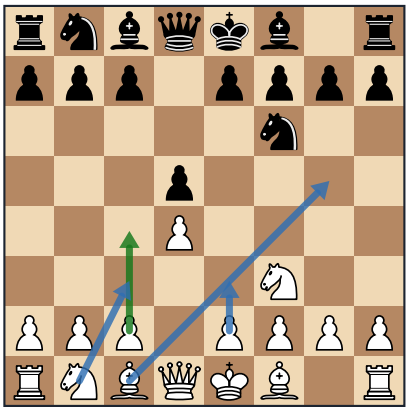


Position after the line

Accelerated London System D00 | 5 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Bf4`

Stockfish: **+0.08** (equal, depth 18). Best next move: c5.
What to look for: d5 (hold the center); e6 (solid); Nf6 (develop)
Sub-variations: Steinitz Countergambit, Steinitz Countergambit Accepted



Position after the line

Symmetrical Variation D02 | 4 lines

`1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+0.32** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best next move: c4.
What to look for: c4 (attack d5); Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop)
Sub-variations: Pseudo-Catalan

Expert and coach view

Capablanca and Karpov played the Queen's Gambit Declined with great success.

What a coach would tell you

Know the three structures: Carlsbad (minority attack), IQP (attack vs blockade) and hanging pawns. Study the plans for each, then choose the QGD, Slav or QGA based on your style.

Why play it

The classical 1.d4 opening: White fights for e4 and the center; Black chooses solid structures (QGD, Slav) or active ones (QGA).

Typical mistakes

• Taking on c4 without a plan to hold the pawn (...b5) or return it.

• Playing Bg5 too early or Nf3 too early without considering ...Ne4 or ...c5.

• Ignoring the minority attack and allowing a permanently weak c6 pawn.

Typical tactics and traps

• Elephant Trap: 1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Nbd7 5.cxd5 exd5 6.Nxd5? Nxd5! 7.Bxd8 Bb4+ and Black wins.

• Back-rank tactics when queens trade and the rooks are unconnected.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

QGD endings are usually balanced; Black's solid structure makes winning chances hard for White.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Queen's Pawn Game (all lines)** — A40
  `1.d4`
  - **Veresov Attack** — A46
    `1.d4`
    - **Dutch System** — A80
      `1.d4 -> 1...f5 2.Nc3 d5`
    - **Classical Defense** — A46
      `1.d4 -> 1...Nf6 2.Nf3 e6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bg5`
  - **Modern Defense** — A40
    `1.d4 -> 1...g6`
  - **Accelerated London System** — D00
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Bf4`
    - **Steinitz Countergambit** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 -> 2...c5`
      - **Morris Countergambit** — D00
        `1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 c5 -> 3.e4`
      - **Morris Countergambit Accepted** — D00
        `1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 c5 -> 3.e4 dxe4`
    - **Steinitz Countergambit Accepted** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 -> 2...c5 3.dxc5`
  - **Chigorin Variation** — D00
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nc3`
    - **Alburt Defense** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bf5`
    - **Anti-Veresov** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 -> 2...Bg4`
    - **Irish Gambit** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 -> 2...c5`
    - **Shaviliuk Gambit** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 -> 2...e5`
    - **Shropshire Defense** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nc3 -> 2...h5`
    - **Fianchetto Defense** — D00
      `1.d4 g6 2.Nf3 Bg7 3.Nc3 d5`
  - **Levitsky Attack** — D00
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Bg5`
    - **Welling Variation** — D00
      `1.d4 d5 2.Bg5 -> 2...Bg4`
    - **Euwe Variation** — D02
      `1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 c6 3.Bg5 h6 4.Bh4 Qb6`
      - **Modern Line** — D02
        `1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 c6 3.Bg5 h6 4.Bh4 Qb6`
  - **Mason Attack** — D00
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.f4`
  - **Zukertort Variation** — D02
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3`
  - **Zurich Gambit** — D00
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.g4`
  - **Anglo-Slav Opening** — A40
    `1.d4 -> 1...c6 2.c4 d6`
  - **Anti-Torre** — D02
    `1.Nf3 d5 2.d4 Bg4`
  - **Krause Variation** — D02
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 c5`
  - **Rossolimo Variation** — A41
    `1.d4 -> 1...d6 2.Nf3 g6`
  - **Symmetrical Variation** — D02
    `1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6`

- **Pseudo-Catalan** D02
  1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 -> 3.g3
- **Colle System** D04
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3
  - **Anti-Colle** D04
    1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3 -> 3...Bf5
  - **Grünfeld Formation** D04
    1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e3 -> 3...g6 4.Bd3 Bg7
  - **Traditional Colle** D05
    1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 e6 3.e3 c5 4.Bd3 d5 5.c3
- **Hübsch Gambit** D00
  1.d4 -> 1...Nf6 2.Nc3 d5 3.e4
- **Liedmann Gambit** A43
  1.d4 -> 1...c5 2.c4 cxd4 3.e3
- **London System** D02
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bf4
  - **with e6** D02
    1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 e6 3.Bf4
  - **Pterodactyl Variation** D02
    1.d4 g6 2.Nf3 Bg7 3.Bf4 c5 4.c3 cxd4 5.cxd4 Qa5
- **Stonewall Attack** D00
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.e3 Nf6 3.Bd3
- **Torre Attack** D03
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5
  - **Gossip Variation** D03
    1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5 -> 3...Ne4
  - **Grünfeld Variation** D03
    1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5 -> 3...g6
    - **Main Line** A48
      1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Bg5 Bg7 4.Nbd2 d5 5.e3 O-O
  - **Breyer Variation** A46
    1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 e6 3.Bg5 d5 4.e3 c5 5.c3 Qb6
- **Veresov** A45
  1.d4 -> 1...Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.Nc3
  - **Richter Attack** A45
    1.d4 Nf6 2.f3 d5 3.Nc3
- **Zilbermints Countergambit** D02
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.c4 b5
- **Barry Attack** A48
  1.d4 -> 1...Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4
  - **Tarzan Attack** A48
    1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Qd2
  - **Grünfeld Variation** A48
    1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Nc3 d5 4.Bf4 -> 4...Bg7 5.e3 O-O 6.Be2
- **Chandler Gambit** D02
  1.d4 -> 1...d5 2.Nf3 c5 3.g3 cxd4 4.Bg2

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 d5 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.Bg5 e6 4.e3 c5 5.c3 Nbd7
```

Plan chain

White	c4 -> Nc3 -> Nf3 -> Bg5 -> e3
Black	d5 -> e6 -> Nf6 -> Be7 -> O-O

Three rules to remember

1. c4 vs d5: White takes the center, Black holds with e6 or c6 and breaks with ...c5.

2. White: minority attack, e4 break or Bd3-Qc2 kingside play. Black: ...c5/...e5 breaks and trading light bishops.

3. White wants e4 or a queenside attack; Black wants a pawn break (...c5/...e5) and active bishops.

Pawn structure in one line

c4/d4 against d5: Carlsbad (c6/e6), Slav chain (c6/d5), QGA (White regains c4), IQP or hanging pawns after exchanges. The minority attack (b4-b5) is White's key plan.